Soon

By James Harms

INTRODUCTION

As mere mortals we are extremely uncomfortable with death. The thought of our own mortality terrifies us but perhaps the thought of our loved ones dying scares us even more. One of my favorite quotes about life an death is by Robert Fulghum: I believe that imagination is stronger than knowledge - myth is more potent than history - dreams are more powerful than facts - hope always triumphs over experience - laughter is the cure for grief - love is stronger than death. This poem by James Harms allows us insight into the thoughts of a husband who know his wife is soon to die. Soon by James Harms

He had always supposed he would die first,
before her, though he didn't think about it much.
It was like a secret learned and then forgotten,
a letter that hurts and is hidden away in a trunk.
But he had always assumed that one of many gifts
she would give him would be to bury him,

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and that was that, though now and then,
as he cleaned her hair from a drain or
sliced an apple into wedges for lunch, placing
half on a yellow plate for her, eating the rest
as he stood reading her shopping list taped
to the refrigerator, now and then he thought
of how much harder it is to be left behind,
and for a while he'd feel an ache in his hands,
as if he were trying to hold onto something
too tightly. Twenty-five years ago she was already
twenty years younger than he, sitting outside
his office, her name on a sheet of paper tacked
to the door, her name with others, each listed
by the hour: it was always 3 o'clock with her,
always Wednesdays. And he loved her immediately,
though of course, he hadn't known it right away.
Perhaps one day, as she pulled her books from a bag

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and began to ask a question, pointing at a line in a poem,
perhaps he thought of how much harder it would be for her,
perhaps he thought this before he'd ever kissed her,
before he noticed how her glance left a streak
on his cheek for days, as if her thoughts could touch,
could leave the small bruises love leaves early on.
But even then there was nothing he could do about it.
Once, years after, he awoke from a dream where
he had watched her from a stand of black oaks
as she dropped a daisy in his grave. And later,
still dreaming, he had circled in the air above their bed
as she tossed loosely in the sheets without him

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like an empty cup blown with paper down the street;
she had been wearing a shirt he'd left dirty in the hamper.
She wrapped her arms around his pillow
as though it were a sack of stones, as though it held her
in place on the earth, kept her from rising to join him.
And when he drifted on her breath out the open window
he had reached to grab the curtains; he had wanted
to stay with her, though he was nothing then, a breeze,
his hands passing through the thin fabric like smoke
through a screen. And for the rest of the dream
he wandered through their town disrupting
leaves gathered in the gutters, cooling a hot cheek here

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and there: a breeze. He never told her of his dream.
Sometimes he watched her from the porch as she stooped
and straightened in the small side garden.
He watched her pull the carrots from the earth,
how she shook them gently before dropping them
in the basket. She wore around her neck
a small woven sack on a string, and in it kept
a quarter: if ever far from home and stranded
she could call. But she was never far from home.
And the sack lifted away from her breast as she bent
to pull a weed; it swung back and forth
like a hypnotist's watch; she took it off only
to sleep. And when he awoke before her each morning
he thought of her alone in the empty house

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tending to the three cats, winding the clocks,
the few things he now did, stacking logs
on the front porch each October, phoning for oil
when the furnace went cold, filling the feeder
by the kitchen door. And of course it hurt him
to imagine her alone, as it hurts him now
to imagine what becomes of those who go, or worse,
of those who stay behind as wind, as small eddies of air.
He gathers the laundry in piles, wonders where
she kept the bleach. He lifts the sash, lets in
a soft wind hoping for the smell of lilacs,
though it's early yet, only April. He will have to wait
for lilacs, and for whatever she planted in the garden.
It is too soon to know for sure what is there.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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